
He Made One of 2024's Breakout Hits. His New HBO Series Is Another Magnum Opus.

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Imogen West-Knights

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I don't envy Richard Gadd the task of following up on his smash hit show of 2024, [Baby Reindeer](#). Gadd's debut, a drama/thriller that billed itself as a "true story" about a man's entanglement with a stalker, shot to the top of the Netflix charts unexpectedly and threw its creator into the limelight in queasy ways when the woman on whom the show's stalker was apparently based [revealed her identity](#) and [went on Piers Morgan's show](#) to address what she saw as an unacceptable and public character assassination. The noise around the real-life origins of *Baby Reindeer* became louder than the noise about the series itself, and cemented the show as a must-watch cultural phenomenon, one that has been rewarded with six Emmys. So a second series from its creator and star Gadd carries both the weight of a need to prove that *Baby Reindeer* wasn't a lone bolt of lightning and a need to reach escape velocity from the discourse about the muddy ethical issues of making a show based on real life.

Now we have that second show: *Half Man*, which premieres on HBO on Thursday night. The six-part drama is a chance for Gadd to show the world who he is as an artist and what his ongoing concerns will be after the publicity maelstrom that surrounded his first show. Like *Baby Reindeer*, *Half Man* is a very well-made and well-written series that I am glad I saw and never want to see again.

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Half Man tells the story of two brothers—although not actually related—called Ruben (Gadd) and Niall (Jamie Bell, of *Billy Elliot* fame), following them from their late teens until roughly their 40s. Every episode begins and ends at Niall's wedding in the present day. Ruben has suddenly turned up, determined to engineer a showdown of some kind with his brother. In between these scenes, we learn about the events that led up to this day. Ruben and Niall grew up in Scotland, where they found themselves sharing a bedroom in their late teens after their mothers begin a relationship and Ruben gets out of a young-offender institute. Ruben was serving time for an act of violence, the first in a series of incredibly brutal crimes that he will go on to commit in the show. Niall, a mild-mannered, closeted boy, is both terrified of and infatuated with his new brother, who in turn

becomes fiercely protective of him—so much so that when Niall goes off to study at university, Ruben comes to visit and does something with terrible, life-changing consequences for several characters. From here, their lives are bound together in a visceral love–hate relationship. They go through several reversals of positions, with one doing well while the other struggles, and their relationship ebbs and flows with these changes.

Gadd has taken on several meaty topics here, most of which were also part of the mix in *Baby Reindeer*: masculinity, sexuality, the lasting effects of trauma, and class, to name a few, and all of them are depicted as sites of intense and bleak struggle. Gadd's worlds are brutal, and there are times in *Half Man* when it feels laid on a little too thick. One character's failed suicide attempt is one such moment when I thought, *Good grief, maybe that's enough misery to pile into one man's life story*. A little well-judged comedy lifts the mood fractionally here and there (Ruben, reflecting on Niall's performance as Hamlet in a student play: "At one stage, you were talking to a skull; the cunt's dead, what are you talking to him for?"), but what saves the show from feeling gratuitously dark is the richness of the way it weaves all the sorry elements of the two men's lives together. That, plus the feral brilliance of the two central performances from Bell and Gadd himself, who has undergone a radical physical transformation since his lanky *Baby Reindeer* days into a muscle-bound bruiser.

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The clearest through line from *Baby Reindeer* is a bold and often uncomfortable insistence on refusing clear morality. Gadd, it seems, has a sustained interest in making work that doesn't offer easy lessons. Ruben does monstrous things. Aside from his grotesque violence in fits of rage, he spits at a woman who flirts with him and then justifies it to Niall by saying, "If you give your body away so easily like that, don't be upset if it comes back with spit on it." We also learn of the terrible suffering Ruben went through as a child, and we see him do things like volunteering with vulnerable boys at a youth center. These scenes don't justify Ruben's crimes, but they do complicate our picture of villainy and victimhood in general. It's unsettling, no doubt intentionally so. But it feels true to life, albeit a truth that it is generally simpler not to try to grapple with on television.

If *Baby Reindeer* tested the limits of audience sympathy with its central character, *Half Man*

disregards those limits entirely. It doesn't feel important to the show whether we like Ruben, who of course we don't, or even Niall. Niall does plenty of monstrous things of his own, though his form of violence is psychological rather than physical. What is important is that we understand the fatal dance in which these men find themselves. There is a vein of Greek tragedy in the story of two brothers inseparably bonded and destined to destroy each other. Where Gadd goes now after *Half Man*, to follow what feels like another magnum opus, is anybody's guess. But I recall thinking that after watching *Baby Reindeer* too, and look at the astonishing work he gave us next.

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